A SELECTION OF 10 COUPLETS

10

திருக்குறள்

Thirukkural

Ten selected couplets

TAMIL, POLSKI, ENGLISH

Original Tamil, translations and pronunciation guides

Sample edition

Reading this collection

People sometimes ask under my Thirukkural videos whether these verses are available in Polish. That question inspired this little collection: a book that Tamil and Polish readers can open together, even if they do not speak each other's language.

Each couplet appears in its original Tamil script, followed by a Latin-letter guide to reading it aloud. The Polish translation has its own English-style pronunciation guide, so Tamil speakers can try reading the Polish too. The English translation offers a shared way to understand the meaning.

> These are just ten of the 1,330 couplets attributed to the poet Thiruvalluvar. For this first selection, I chose verses about speech, friendship, learning and everyday life.

KURAL 1

Beginnings

TAMIL தமிழ்

அகர முதல எழுத்தெல்லாம் ஆதி
பகவன் முதற்றே உலகு.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Akara mudhala ezhuththellaam aadhi / Pakavan mudhatre ulaku

POLSKI

Jak litera A jest pierwsza w alfabecie, tak Bóg jest początkiem świata.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

yahk lee-teh-rah ah yest pyerf-shah v ahl-fah-beh-chyeh, tahk book yest poh-chon-tkyehm shvyah-tah

ENGLISH

As A comes first among letters, so God is first in the world.

KURAL 100

Words and fruit

TAMIL தமிழ்

இனிய உளவாக இன்னாத கூறல்
கனிஇருப்பக் காய்கவர்ந் தற்று.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Iniya ulavaaka innaadha kooral / Kaniiruppak kaaikavarn thatru

POLSKI

Mówić przykre słowa, gdy można mówić życzliwie, to jak wybierać niedojrzały owoc, choć obok leży dojrzały.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

moo-veetch pshih-kreh swoh-vah, gdih mozh-nah moo-veetch zhihch-lee-vyeh, toh yahk vih-byeh-rahch nyeh-doy-zhah-wih oh-vohts, hohch oh-bohk leh-zhih doy-zhah-wih

ENGLISH

To speak harshly when kind words are possible is to choose unripe fruit while ripe fruit is at hand.

KURAL 129

Wounds from words

TAMIL தமிழ்

தீயினாற் சுட்டபுண் உள்ளாறும் ஆறாதே
நாவினாற் சுட்ட வடு.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Theeyinaar suttapun ullaarum aaraadhe / Naavinaar sutta vatu

POLSKI

Oparzenie może się zagoić, ale rana zadana słowami może nie zagoić się nigdy.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

oh-pah-zheh-nyeh moh-zheh shyeh zah-goh-eetch, ah-leh rah-nah zah-dah-nah swoh-vah-mee moh-zheh nyeh zah-goh-eetch shyeh neeg-dih

ENGLISH

A wound caused by fire can heal. A wound made by words may never heal.

KURAL 131

Good conduct

TAMIL தமிழ்

ஒழுக்கம் விழுப்பந் தரலான் ஒழுக்கம் உயிரினும் ஓம்பப் படும்.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Ozhukkam vizhuppan tharalaan ozhukkam / Uyirinum ompap patum

POLSKI

Prawe postępowanie przynosi godność. Chroń je bardziej niż własne życie.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

prah-veh poh-stem-poh-vah-nyeh pshih-noh-shee gohd-noshch. hrohn yeh bar-dzyeh neezh vwas-neh zhih-chyeh

ENGLISH

Good conduct brings dignity; guard it more carefully than life itself.

KURAL 314

Kindness instead of revenge

TAMIL தமிழ்

இன்னாசெய் தாரை ஒறுத்தல்
அவர்நாண
நன்னயஞ் செய்து விடல்.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Innaasey thaarai oruththal avarnaana / Nannayanj cheydhu vital

POLSKI

Za zło odpłać dobrem, by sprawca poczuł wstyd. Potem zapomnij zarówno o krzywdzie, jak i o własnym dobrym uczynku.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

zah zwoh oht-pwatch doh-brehm, bih spraf-tsah poh-choow fstihd. poh-tehm zah-pohm-neey zah-roov-noh oh kshihv-dzyeh, yahk ee oh vwahs-nim doh-brim oo-chin-koo

ENGLISH

Repay a wrong with goodness, so the wrongdoer feels ashamed. Then forget both the wrong and the good you did.

KURAL 391

Uczyć się i żyć

TAMIL தமிழ்

கற்க கசடறக் கற்பவை கற்றபின்
நிற்க அதற்குத் தக.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Karka kasatarak karpavai katrapin / Nirka adharkuth thaka

POLSKI

Ucz się starannie tego, co warto wiedzieć. Potem postępuj zgodnie z tym, czego się nauczyłeś.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

ooch shyeh stah-rahn-nyeh teh-goh, tsoh var-toh vyeh-dzyech. poh-tehm poh-stem-pooy zgohd-nyeh z tihm, cheh-goh shyeh nah-oo-chih-wesh

ENGLISH

Learn thoroughly what is worth learning, then live by what you have learned.

KURAL 423

Rozpoznać prawdę

TAMIL தமிழ்

எப்பொருள் யார்யார்வாய்க்
கேட்பினும் அப்பொருள்
மெய்ப்பொருள் காண்ப தறிவு.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Epporul yaaryaarvaaik ketpinum apporul / Meypporul kaanpa tharivu

POLSKI

Mądrość to umieć rozpoznać prawdę w tym, co słyszymy, niezależnie od tego, kto mówi.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

mon-droshch toh oo-myehch rohz-pohz-nahtch prahv-deh f tihm, tsoh swih-shih-mih, nyeh-zah-lehzh-nyeh oht teh-goh, ktoh moo-vee

ENGLISH

Wisdom is to recognize the truth in what is said, whoever the speaker may be.

KURAL 786

Uśmiech serca

TAMIL தமிழ்

முகநக நட்பது நட்பன்று நெஞ்சத்து அகநக நட்பது நட்பு.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Mukanaka natpadhu natpandru nenjaththu / Akanaka natpadhu natpu

POLSKI

Nie sam uśmiech na twarzy świadczy o przyjaźni, lecz uśmiech, który rodzi się w sercu.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

nyeh sahm oo-shmyeh-h nah tfah-zhih shvyahd-chih oh pshih-yahzh-nee, lets oo-shmyeh-h, ktoor-ih roh-dzee shyeh f sehr-tsoo

ENGLISH

A smile on the face alone is not friendship. True friendship smiles from the heart.

KURAL 972

Równi urodzeniem

TAMIL தமிழ்

பிறப்பொக்கும் எல்லா உயிர்க்கும்
சிறப்பொவ்வா
செய்தொழில் வேற்றுமை யான்.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Pirappokkum ellaa uyirkkum sirappovvaa / Seydhozhil vetrumai yaan

POLSKI

Wszyscy rodzimy się równi. O tym, czym się wyróżniamy, decydują nasze czyny.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

fshihs-tsih roh-dzee-mih shyeh roov-nee. oh tihm, chim shyeh vih-roozh-nyah-mih, deh-tsih-doo-yon nah-sheh chih-nih

ENGLISH

All are equal by birth; it is their actions that distinguish them.

KURAL 1033

Working the land

TAMIL தமிழ்

உழுதுண்டு வாழ்வாரே வாழ்வார்மற் றெல்லாம்
தொழுதுண்டு பின்செல் பவர்.

How to say it in Tamil (Latin letters)

Uzhudhuntu vaazhvaare vaazhvaarmar rellaam / Thozhudhuntu pinsel pavar

POLSKI

Kto żyje z uprawy ziemi, żyje niezależnie. Inni polegają na cudzej pracy.

How to say it in Polish (English-style spelling)

ktoh zhih-yeh z oo-prah-vih zyeh-mee, zhih-yeh nyeh-zah-lehzh-nyeh. een-nee poh-leh-gah-yon nah tsoo-dzhey praht-sih

ENGLISH

Those who live by cultivating the land live on their own terms; others depend on other people.

Translations and pronunciation

The Polish and English texts in this booklet are newly written, meaning-focused renderings of the couplets. They do not attempt to reproduce the original Tamil metre.

The Tamil pronunciation lines use a simplified Latin-letter spelling. Doubled vowels, such as *aa*, generally indicate a longer vowel sound. Tamil *zh* represents a sound without a straightforward English equivalent.

In the English-style guide to Polish, *sh* stands for Polish *sz*, *ch* for *cz*, *zh* for *ż/rz*, and *ts* for *c*. The letter *w* is used for Polish *ł*. Polish usually stresses the second-to-last syllable. These are reading aids, not exact phonetic transcriptions.

SOURCES AND TEXT CHECKS

The Tamil text, verse numbers and meanings were checked against kurals 1, 100, 129, 131, 314, 391, 423, 786, 972 and 1033 at Thirukkural.net, including the commentaries available there.

www.thirukkural.net/en/

Created by Oliwia from Poland

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